in favor of

Rebuttal to Argument ~~for~~ Measure U

Berkeley absolutely needs to invest in its aging capital infrastructure. The question is whether taxpayers need to authorize $300 million in *new* debt—costing roughly $550–600 million with interest — without a clear, prioritized plan.

In 2024, City leaders persuaded voters to approve Measure FF, one of the largest annual parcel taxes in history, promising "*More than double the funding for street paving, safety improvements, and environmental enhancements…twice as much funding to fix potholes…and twice as much money to win critical infrastructure grants." (2024 Voter Guide)*

Voters also approved a 2020 parcel tax to address wildfire risk and emergency preparedness.

With the generous taxes passed in 2020 and 2024, why is the City demanding yet another tax? Why can't they deliver on their past promises, within the means we've already approved?

Measure U isn't even a commitment to the entire list of projects. It does not tell voters which projects take priority, their lifecycle costs, when or even whether they will be built, or how they will be maintained.

Before assuming hundreds of millions of dollars in new debt, Berkeley should account for why existing infrastructure taxes are not sufficient, identify its highest priorities, establish realistic costs and schedules, and demonstrate how those investments will be maintained.

Berkeley needs infrastructure investment. What it does not need is another enormous blank check for redundant purposes without a realistic plan for spending it.

Vote NO.

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CITY OF BERKELEY
CITY CLERK DEPARTMENT

s/Donna DiDiemar
Neighborhood Activist and Former Small Business Owner

s/Paul Mathew
Building Decarbonization Consultant

s/McKinley Crespo
Small Business Owner

s/Steve Robey
Retired IT Consultant

Submitted on behalf of: Affordable Berkeley. Isabelle Gaston, Assistant Treasurer

Isabelle Gaston